



Job security: “Earlier, in my time, even if you were an IM, you could get job opportunities. Railways, banks and oil companies like IOCL, Bharat Petroleum and ONGC recruited chess players. But subsequent generations did not have the same opportunity and had to explore other avenues,” says coach R. B. Ramesh, a Dronacharya award winner.

Woman Grandmaster (WGM) and an International Master (IM), Vijayalakshmi won six National championships and two individual silver medals on the top board at the Chess Olympiad.

Winning the title of GM requires a player to complete three GM norms and achieve a 2500 rating. Earning these norms requires a 2600+ tournament rating over a FIDE-approved event of at least nine rounds. The player must face opponents from at least three different federations, where at least 50% hold international titles, and at least one-third are already GMs.

Vijayalakshmi secured four GM norms. By her own admission, her live rating peaked to 2498 once, but the sacred mark remained painstakingly out of reach. The narrow miss cannot be separated from the circumstances on which her career was built. Her father, A. S. Subbaraman, introduced her to chess and remained her only coach. With three daughters to support and

no chess background in the family, her parents made sacrifices she understands better now that she is a parent herself. At the height of their financial difficulties, her father would pawn jewellery to fund tournaments. All this for a sport still in its infancy in the country and with no ready-made pathway to success.

Travelling abroad was another challenge. Subbaraman could accompany her to domestic competitions but never travelled overseas with her. Going abroad for a single tournament cost around INR 4-7 lakh back in the late 1990s, Vijayalakshmi said. So, her only option to undertake these trips was as part of the Indian team sponsored by the federation. “We used to have our own utensils and a cooker and carry these big suitcases alone, because it was only the accommodation the organisers used to give,” she explains.

“The process to earn these norms is quite long, and the main [issue] is the financial aspect. If you can

contribute more, you can achieve things quicker,” says A. Harshini, a Woman FIDE Master and a silver medallist in Asian Youth Under-18 girls. “I would go to tournaments in Europe for 1-2 months and then forced to take a break. We didn’t have the opportunity to score IM and GM norms here. Many talented players have missed their milestones because of the lack of financial support,” Harshini adds.

The volume of red tape in executing these trips didn’t help either. “Tournaments in India were few and far between. Exploring options in Europe was very bureaucratic. You needed government approval for everything. To get foreign exchange, we needed to write to the sports ministry and then to the RBI in Delhi,” explains R. B. Ramesh, India’s 10th GM.

Decades later, despite the GM count now surging to 99 and chess players continuously emerging across many pockets in the country, India still rarely hosts tournaments